

Under Windows Vista Ultimate, the feature is also used to push through special software meant for the Vista Ultimate user, called Ultimate Extras; for example, DreamScene, the program that allows you to set a video file as your wallpaper, is downloadable through Windows Update.

By default, Windows Update is switched on during install, but can be turned off through the Control Panel. Vista also includes options which let you control how you are notified about the availability of updates, as well as the option to review and approve updates before they are downloaded or installed. You can also proactively check to see if any updates are available for your PC.

While you can deactivate Windows Updates, doing so is not recommended, since it is a vital component for ensuring that your system is plugged of newly-discovered holes, and that your virus definitions are up-to-date. An update is classified by Microsoft as Important, Recommended, and Optional. Under Vista, Windows Update can automatically download and install both Important and Recommended updates. Previously, only updates classified as High Priority could be installed automatically, and you had to manually select and download other available updates. You can also hide updates that are not relevant to your operating system (such as language packs). Details and notes around an update can be accessed by right-clicking on an update element and clicking on “View details”. Windows Update keeps a history of all the updates you have downloaded and installed on your operating system, which can be useful if your system gets unstable after an update and you need to track the guilty update.

Updating of the system and software occurs in the background, and flexible options are provided for completing the updating process. If an update requires a restart to complete installation, you can schedule the restart for a future time when it won’t disrupt your work. You can also postpone a previously-scheduled restart until your current work is complete. Finally, when a software update applies to a file in use, Windows Vista can save